

Research and Planning

Author(s)	Title, Publication Year, Type	Notes
Allen J. Scott	On Hollywood: The Place, the Industry (2005) Type: Book	Valuable information on Hollywood in the 21 st century.
Thorsten Hennig-Thurau, S. Abraham Ravid, Olav Sorenson	The Economics of Filmed Entertainment in the Digital Era (2021) Type: From Journal of Cultural Economics	Relevant and current, contextualizing the film industry from the perspective of the COVID-19 era and convenience of digital streaming services.
Katie Kilkenny	Who's Going to Halt Hollywood's Production Exodus — and How? (2025) Type: News Article, The Hollywood Reporter	Highly relevant and current, covering the political economy, labor issues, and policy battles pushing film production out of California. It links local economic impacts, including in LA's suburbs, to global trade debates. Different levels of the film industry can be contextualized (state, national, global). Illustrates the complex institutional forces (political, economic) behind the decline in California filming.
Megan Jamerson	Hollywood's filming decline hits local small businesses in L.A. (2025) Type: Radio Podcast, Transcript	Contextualizes current immediate effects on local suburban businesses (i.e. Burbank) and how business owners have seen less customers. Support needed with concrete evidence to avoid correlation not causation issues when integrating this source. References several other sources that are of relevance. Mentions film incentive programs.

Organizing sources in a tabular manner helped me worry less about if I would use the source and focus more on the ideas in a source that caught my attention. Many sources I never ended up incorporating into my drafts of the Contexts Project. Yet this process allowed me to look over the content of many sources leading me into other potential sources and so on. Rather than having a bunch of browser tabs open, this method was certainly more organized and allowed me to focus on what I wanted to discuss in my paper.

The COVID-19 pandemic marked a dramatic turning point in Hollywood's economic and technological landscape, rapidly intensifying trends that had been developing for decades. Economic researchers Thorsten Hennig-Thurau, S. Abraham Ravid, and Olav Sorenson, writing in the *Journal of Cultural Economics*, explain that "COVID-19, if anything, has accelerated this transformation. When the pandemic kept people home, streaming services came to the rescue, providing audiences with filmed entertainment on their televisions, computers, tablets, and other digital devices."¹ From their perspective as economists studying the film industry, digitalization is portrayed as a monumental shift, comparable in scale to past technological leaps such as sound and color, but ultimately part of the film industry's long history of adapting to innovation. They suggest that although traditional business models are destabilized, these changes present new strategic opportunities, urging readers to "embrace these opportunities, find ways to overcome the research challenges of the 'new' digitalized industry, and continue the quest to shed light on and guide the industry's future paths."² They frame the disruption of long established practices in the film industry in a positive light for businesses and shareholders implying that the industry is resilient and capable of evolving when coupled with technological advancements.

In contrast, Paris Marx, a tech-industry researcher, adopts a far more critical stance toward these developments through the lens of a consumer and writer. Writing in his newsletter *Disconnect*, Marx argues that the digital shift has resulted in the merging of widespread industry corporations while undermining the quality of life of writers. He observes that "what's happened here is twofold: Companies are merging, which gives them even greater leverage against workers, but also any smaller companies that depend on them for business, like cinemas. Plus, they're developing and rolling out new technologies that restructure the conditions of the industry to further enhance their power."³ Unlike the economists' somewhat optimistic view of digitalization as a field of new business possibilities, Marx emphasizes how streaming platforms and major conglomerates have weaponized technological change to reduce costs, minimize residual payments, and potentially replace human workers altogether with artificial intelligence. "After this decades-long process of digitization, consolidation, and centralizing power on the part of major entertainment conglomerates, they're wielding it to further transform the face of the industry and what it means to work in it,"⁴ Marx warns, specifically citing the recent Writers Guild strikes as a response to these threats. While Hennig-Thurau et al. acknowledge that digitalization disrupts old patterns, Marx underscores how this disruption translates into job losses, precarious working conditions, and declining power for creative laborers.

1. Hennig-Thurau, Thorsten, S. Abraham Ravid, and Olav Sorenson. "The Economics of Filmed Entertainment in the Digital Era." *Journal of Cultural Economics* 45, no. 1 (2021): 157–170. <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10824-021-09407-6>
2. Marx, Paris. "How Hollywood Studios Used the Digital Transition to Crush Workers." *Disconnect (Blog)*, May 4, 2023. <https://www.disconnect.blog/p/how-hollywood-studios-used-the-digital>.

The COVID-19 pandemic marked a dramatic turning point in Hollywood's economic and technological landscape that increased the demand for many popular streaming services. Industries may continue to see streaming services as a worthwhile investment in recovering from the pandemic. Economic researchers Thorsten Hennig-Thurau, S. Abraham Ravid, and Olav Sorenson, writing in the *Journal of Cultural Economics*, explain that "COVID-19, if anything, has accelerated this transformation. When the pandemic kept people home, streaming services came to the rescue, providing audiences with filmed entertainment on their televisions, computers, tablets, and other digital devices" (Hennig-Thurau et al., 157). From their perspective as economists studying the film industry, digitalization is portrayed as a monumental shift, comparable in scale to past technological leaps such as sound and color, but ultimately part of the film industry's long history of adapting to innovation. They suggest that although traditional business models are destabilized, these changes present new strategic opportunities, urging readers to "embrace these opportunities, find ways to overcome the research challenges of the 'new' digitalized industry, and continue the quest to shed light on and guide the industry's future paths" (Hennig-Thurau et al., 160). Economics researchers continue to observe the developing digitalized industry as they mention. They frame the disruption of long-established practices in the film industry in a positive light for businesses and shareholders implying that the industry is resilient and capable of evolving when coupled with technological advancements. With growing popularity in streaming especially due to its convenience, these claims seem to justify an inevitable shift of the film and TV industry in providing these services. In contrast, Paris Marx, a tech-industry researcher, adopts a far more critical stance toward these developments through the lens of a consumer and writer. Writing in his newsletter *Disconnect*, Marx argues that the digital shift has resulted in the merging of widespread industry corporations while undermining the quality of life of writers. He observes that "what's happened here is twofold: Companies are merging, which gives them even greater leverage against workers, but also any smaller companies that depend on them for business, like cinemas. Plus, they're developing and rolling out new technologies that restructure the conditions of the industry to further enhance their power." Unlike the economists' somewhat optimistic view of digitalization as a field of new business possibilities, Marx emphasizes how streaming platforms and major conglomerates have weaponized technological change to reduce costs, minimize residual payments, and potentially replace human workers altogether with artificial intelligence. "After this decades-long process of digitization, consolidation, and centralizing power on the part of major entertainment conglomerates, they're wielding it to further transform the face of the industry and what it means to work in it," Marx warns, specifically citing the recent WGA strikes as a response to these threats (Paris). While Marx's blog post may portray the situation as in favor of the industries, unions possess considerable power against them in the 21st century. This power in the hands of the labor force is another cause as to why industries are currently struggling to reduce production costs overall. In 2023, an editor for *The Guardian* Betsy Reed reports that the WGA successfully obtained a contract that "guarantees that AI is not considered a 'writer', that companies cannot force writers to use AI, and that companies must disclose if writers are given any AI-generated material to work with" (Reed). Workers' leverage against companies adapting technological developments continues to grow with this victory paving a way for the labor force to gain more power over the industry itself. Growing opposing forces from workers may cause industries to face rising costs which only provides further incentives to reduce overall production costs by any means. Adapting new technological developments is one method that can be used to remedy rising labor costs. Yet, workers may see these advancements as a threat to their livelihood in fear of industries relying more on growing technologies over traditional manpower.

From the Integrating Sources assignment, I adapted the paragraphs I wrote into the Contexts Project. I felt more comfortable with using the quote-sandwich method coming from this assignment. In the adaptation in my final draft of the Contexts Project (right), I use more quotes and explanations aimed at contextualizing the socioeconomic situation between strikes and technological developments in conversation.

Revising and Collaborating

General Feedback

- I really liked your flow, the way you integrate your evidence was flawless and the evidence you provide was both credible and relevant to your topic and you introduce it into your ideas very well
- There was definitely a good amount of both scholarly sources as well as popular sources such as radio show transcripts and news reports and both kinds of sources are used very well
- I really liked the graphs and visual aspects that you added to your context project, it was very helpful to look back upon when I got lost in the paragraph to understand again what your paragraph was trying to say
- I think that your intro paragraph was very well written however I felt like you could have written better body paragraphs in the sense that you don't really directly say what the topic is about in the paragraphs, the reader has to guess it through the quotes and evidence and limited analysis that you provide in each paragraph so I would recommend telling the reader in the first line about what each paragraph is about
- Your paper follows MLA formatting very well except for the evidence citations but as far as spacing and headers and bibliography and title you have done a good job in that aspect
- I would add a concluding paragraph to your essay about everything that you went over and leave the reader with a closing thought or two. I think it's a good idea especially because your topic is complex and you are talking about and explaining many different aspects about how Hollywood has changed after COVID 19 so it would be good to get a quick revision about everything that you went over in case it wasn't already present or understandable in the paper.
- Consider adding subheaders in the paper so that it is a little more clear about what you are talking about and it looks a little more professional rather than having an extensive intro sentence about what each paragraph is about.
- I liked your grammar and choice of words, it is very sophisticated but not too complicated as I didn't have to reread each sentence just to understand it. I really liked this blend of professional and casual language that you incorporated into your paper and that is something that I can implement in mine.
- Overall good job

Overall Feedback

- You did a really good job on this essay! I feel like I was able to understand the points you were making, and I like the background information you give with the sources. You do an amazing job at formatting, especially with quotes and whenever you include a picture in your essay you have a caption to back it up.
 - I feel like for the conclusion paragraph you could re-iterate your original thesis statement just to put readers in the right direction for what the conclusion paragraph will be about, and to have it more clear by including the reiteration of your thesis statement.
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- I feel like my overall critique is to have more of your own writing backing up your quotes. Throughout the essay, I felt like I was reading a lot of quotes which is a good thing! But for the next draft, I'd try to put an emphasis on analyzing the quotes you include to have your opinion and perspective on what you're trying to convey through this essay.

My peers had similar ideas to share about my draft with a holistic approach to critique on how I could read more into my sources and provide my own insight more clearly. They also criticized the lack of a clearly defined thesis which I agreed with and improved in my following drafts. Generally, feedback didn't conflict in the process.

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Anthony James Ahn <ahna2@uci.edu>

to Pranay, Allen, Vincent

Jul 12, 2025, 11:53 PM

☆ ↶ ⋮

Hey y'all, apologies for the late reply. Attached are my annotations/comments for each of your essays. Overall, good development of ideas and a solid foundation going into the second/final drafts.

To see the comments, open the PDF in any Chromium-based browser (i.e. Edge, Opera, Chrome, Firefox, etc.) and you should be able to hover over highlighted text to see in-line comments. There are also final comments written towards the end of each essay.

2 Attachments • Scanned by Gmail

Allen Mara Conte...

Pranay Choudhar...

As a peer editor, I aimed to write comments as short as possible while providing meaningful critique. I did this by adding inline comments in a PDF editor to allow my peers to see exactly which line I was commenting about with each note. I feel my feedback between both peers is similar as I feel I let my biases from my own writing latch on which I tried my best to prevent. Each peer had a very structured approach to their writing while I emphasized content in my earlier draft.

3

Good effort to get into some sources and to understand the issues. We need a clearer argument for the final. What are the main three or few things that have happened, in historical order, and what is the big point about their effect that you helps us understand the move of much capital and jobs out of SoCal and the current tightening or slowing of the relevant industries, respectively? Finally, what are the impacts for the workers most affected and for SoCal areas most affected? I think you'll need to do some more reading, more staring at your current sources, and maybe make a leap to tell us what you think, even if you're not certain, about the causes and impacts. Saying something is possibly or probably the case is just as strong as saying it's certainly the case, when we're trying to understand such complex stuff as scholars, but we very clearly want to make such claims as the outcome of our paragraphs.

Vincent Roy Hiscock , Jul 19 at 10:16am



Vincent Roy Hiscock

one thing that we need to understand is the disruptions that preceded and motivated the strikes. The Writers Guild, for example, is very worried about shifts to reliance on AI that were already afoot and that they felt threatened a large base of their workers, so they wanted protections against this. Both actors and writers are also responding to a situation where work is not steady in Hollywood; people may be well paid on a project, but then projects might be few and far in between, such that you are in a constant worry over how long your last wages will last and even go out of healthcare. The industries rely on many smaller part workers who are in an especially precarious situation due to this.

I was afraid to take a “leap” into what I thought about some of the information I extracted from my sources which the instructor comments helped my overcome. The comment on the “why” of my context helped me look deeper in my sources and provide my own insight into why Hollywood has become the way it is in present.

Moving Ahead

A fault I had with my Contexts Project is not spending more time with my sources, especially ones with potentially enough information for the entire project itself. I should take into account the strength of my sources in analyzing the different conversations of my context as is necessary for the Advocacy Project. I feel the Advocacy Project will rely more heavily on my own insight for me to deliver a convincing narrative/solution.

A more structured approach to my composition will help me organize my claims

better with the Advocacy Project. I feel the quote-sandwich method of composition is still applicable, however. Yet, I feel it will be more productive if I connect the “conversations” between multiple sources with more diligence.